



## Consumer Culture Theory

Story of Cool: Journey from the West to Emerging Arab Countries

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## PART II

# GLOCALIZATION

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# CHAPTER 5

## STORY OF COOL: JOURNEY FROM THE WEST TO EMERGING ARAB COUNTRIES

Hela Zouaoui and Fatma Smaoui

### ABSTRACT

*Purpose: Cool, a subjective, socially constructed concept has interested several researchers investigating its nature and successful marketing applications. However, the authors note a lack of studies investigating its perceptions in non-Western cultural contexts. The aims of this study are to investigate the meanings of cool in Tunisia, a North-African, Arab-Muslim emerging country.*

*Methodology: The authors conducted qualitative research through focus groups with Tunisian consumers. The authors used lexical, thematic, and semi-otic analyses to investigate cool meanings.*

*Findings: Findings show that the term “Cool” in Tunisia is mostly related to lexical synonyms and meanings of lightness and flexibility, fun and amusement, humor, and trendiness rather than originality, divergence, creativity, and uniqueness long argued to be the significations of cool in Western literature, despite their minor presence in our results.*

*Originality/Value: Results show further evidence that the concept is culturally laden and that the socio-cultural characteristics of Tunisia altered its meanings established in the West, mostly associated to its origins and emergence.*

**Keywords:** Cool; culture; Western; emerging country; Arab country; semiotic

## INTRODUCTION

For many years now, the concept of cool has emerged and became embedded in consumers' ideologies. It originated from Western cultures and perhaps Western Africa before that, particularly in the South Western Nigeria having a mystic meaning as the recognition of inspired goodness (Thompson, 1983). Cool has then emerged in the late 1920s with jazz musicians and was accordingly embodied by blacks and used in the African American vernacular (slang) as an act of resistance to the racial exclusion as well as a detachment from the restrictive unfair society (Pountain & Robins, 2001). Subsequently, cool was associated with meanings of rebellion (Tapp & Bird, 2008; Warren & Campbell, 2014) through the "aggressive" words and divergent images transmitted through their music; cool is indicative of objection and counter-culturalism against other groups and governments (Brooks, 2000) and seen as a cult of cultural authenticity (Thornton, 1995) characterizing thus the lifestyle of the Hippies.

With the globalization taking place and the mass media explosion happening in the 1990s, media started spreading a symbolism-dominant consumerism highly influenced by the Western culture across the globe (Holt & Üstüner, 2010). Several cultures, specifically post-colonial ones, developed a preference for Western products and considered them as powerful global status symbols with superior value (Holt & Üstüner, 2010). Accordingly, they viewed Western culture as hip, attractive and classy (Touzani, Hirschman, & Smaoui, 2016; Wilk, 2006) and tended to imitate it by embracing and adopting its trends and even using its language into their everyday vernacular.

In the case of formerly post-colonial Arab countries like Tunisia, we find a mixture of lifestyles: between the traditional, the Arab-Islamic conservative and the Western-oriented liberal (Smaoui & Ghariani, 2011; Sobh & Belk, 2012; Sobh, Belk, & Gressel, 2014). Tunisia is multicultural and open to Western culture (Abassi, 2005). Bilingualism (Standard Arabic and French) was adopted since its colonization and integrated into its educational system. However, with the increased exposure to international media, along with the widespread presence of the Internet favoring English and Western culture, contemporary Tunisian society has witnessed the embrace of the English language and Western symbols. Accordingly, evidence of the usage of the term "Cool" in the everyday vocabulary as well as in business fields is found in the Tunisian cultural context, despite its foreign origins. Cool is used to label products such as the "Cool & Go" card launched by Tunisian bank *BH*, services like "Cool working space" for the educational and professional space *MediaNet*, programs like "MidiCool" program launched by a Tunisian local radio station and even food and breakfast menus in coffee houses "Formule Cool."

Relying on its characteristics of subjectivity and dynamism (Warren & Campbell, 2014), the understanding of the concept changes among individuals and cultures (Gerber & Geiman, 2012; Gurrieri, 2009). It seems thus interesting to reflect on the meanings of Cool in a non-Western cultural context, Tunisia, an Arab Muslim country of the MENA (Middle East and North African) region. Along with scarce previous non-Western literature approaching this controversial concept, this research study aims to investigate the perceptions and meanings of Cool among Tunisian consumers, especially as it is attributed to many cultural

objects, and its interest to marketing researchers and those investigating its application on the marketplace.

## ABOUT COOL: LITERATURE AND MARKETING PRACTICES

Earliest related works emerged in the psychology and sociology fields dealing with the cool attitude (Frank, 1997; MacAdams, 2001) and cool personalities (Dar-Nimrod et al., 2012) as a taste for and a manifestation of the forbidden, the risky, the subversive, and authentic (Southgate, 2003). As the term emerged with the spread of the postmodern values fragmenting society and tolerating the co-existence of different lifestyle (Baudrillard & Levin, 1981; Gabriel, 1998), cool indicates counter-culturalism, anti-conformism, individualist self-authentic ideology (Brooks, 2000; Thornton, 1995). This results in characteristics of attractiveness and desirability associated with a risky rebellious divergent behavior (Tap & Bird, 2008; Mohiuddin, Gordon, Magee, & Lee, 2016).

Cool became therefore desired and a sought-after quality for individuals and brands, giving it an exciting and appealing nature (Belk, Tian, & Paavola, 2010; Heath & Potter, 2010). Associating it with the marketing field has been proven effective as cool sells products and adds symbolic currency to brands (Warren & Campbell, 2014). The “Coolhunters” (Gladwell, 1997) emerged relatively as a group of practitioners whose job is to detect cool trends (Goodman, 2001) on the market and provide marketers with a meta-code of cool at extremely high prices. We thus find brands and firms nowadays competing to be perceived as cool with the UK annual listing of “Cool brands” (on their related website CoolBrands) along with the San Francisco venture of “Cool Companies.” There have also been governmental programs called Cool Britannia in the UK and Cool Japan in Japan indicating the renaissance of both countries and the association of such concept to the youth.

Embraced by marketing literature, we find several studies related to its origins (O'Donnel & Wardlow, 2000), others highlighting the characteristics of cool products (Holtzblatt, 2010; Im, Bhat, & Lee, 2015; Kerner & Pressman, 2007; Kim, Shin, & Park, 2015; Raptis, Bruun, Kjeldskov, & Skov, 2017; Sundar, 2008; Sundar, Tamul, & Wu, 2014) and cool brands (Loureiro & Lopes, 2012; Warren & Campbell, 2014, 2015) both as a combination of attractiveness and original elements; and coolness from a social marketing perspective as a positioning for social brands (Mohiuddin et al., 2016; Tapp & Bird, 2008).

Although the majority of consumers seem to agree on liking and desiring cool, defining it or agreeing upon a definition of it seems to be much more challenging (Kerner & Pressman, 2007). There is no consensus on what is cool in previous literature (Belk et al., 2010). However, studies seem to agree on several characteristics making things cool. For a start, coolness is a subjective and dynamic construct. In other words, it is continuous and contextual (Warren & Campbell, 2014), it is highly influenced by trends (Frank, 1997; Goodman, 2001) and it changes meanings from one culture to another (Gerber & Geiman, 2012; Gurrieri,

2009; Leland, 2004; Norman, 2004). Furthermore, it is associated with meanings of rebellion, divergence, and originality (Tapp & Bird, 2008; Warren & Campbell, 2014). Most importantly, despite its multiple meanings, coolness is a trait and status associated with positive connotations (Belk et al., 2010; Heath & Potter, 2010; Warren & Campbell, 2014). It is thus desired and attractive (Dar-Nimrod et al., 2012; Kerner & Pressman, 2007; Rahman, 2012), it pleases consumers and adds symbolic value to products and brands (Warren & Campbell, 2014).

As cool is culturally laden, its perception is highly dependent on the cultural context it is established in. Therefore, a brief exposition of the socio-cultural characteristics of Tunisia is essential.

## CULTURAL FRAME: ABOUT TUNISIA

Tunisia is an Arab-Muslim emerging country located in North Africa. As an initially Berber Mediterranean nation with a strategic geographic position, this led to its occupation by several civilizations (Phoenician, Roman, Byzantine, Arab, etc.). Formerly colonized by France (1881–1956) it underwent a revolution against its governor in 2011 that initiated the “Arab Spring,” Tunisia is characterized by the co-existence of various lifestyles representative of both Arabic-Islamic and Western cultures that are significantly contributing to modernizing the country and shaping its new national identity (Hirschman & Touzani, 2011). It is known for its openness to Western culture (Abassi, 2005) and is characterized by a dynamic economy witnessing industrialization. Its market is considered a test market in the MENA region (Touzani, Smaoui, & Laabidi, 2015).

Accordingly, ever since its colonization, it has adopted and integrated French along with Arabic as main languages in the everyday vocabulary and administrative structuring. Furthermore, although its educational system relies on these languages, we note a significant increase in the integration of the English language in schools and universities and its adoption by Tunisians. Partially due to the widespread Western (English speaker) media and Internet, many Tunisians have developed a knowledge of these foreign languages and embedded them into their vernacular.

Giving these characteristics, we chose to conduct our study in Tunisia to investigate their impact on perceptions of Cool, especially since we found evidence of its usage, and the potential changes in its meanings through its journey across cultures (Western vs. non-Western).

## METHODOLOGY

The purpose of the present chapter is exploratory in nature, since it is an attempt to investigate the meanings of a subjective ambiguous concept (Denzin & Lincoln, 2005) that has been little studied in previous literature in non-Western countries. Qualitative research is thus favored following an inductive approach associated with qualitative data (Bryman & Bell, 2015). This latter is most suitable as it allows a better understanding of a cultural phenomenon related to human perceptions (McCracken, 1986).

We opted for focus group as a method of data collection taking advantage of the interactivity among Tunisian consumers that generates ideas and perspectives related to potentially new questions that might appear while conducting the research (Stewart & Shamdasani, 2015). This method also provides rich data especially as it corresponds to the purposes of searching for related vocabulary and perceptions of Cool among the Tunisian consumers “out there” (Krueger, 1994). We conducted two focus groups, with seven and six participants respectively. However, we implemented mini groups of friends among our participants to eliminate any possible shyness that might occur if we had recruited total strangers (Collier & Fuller, 1998).

Because coolness varies within groups of individuals and based on personality traits (Warren & Campbell, 2014), care was given to the interpersonal and individual characteristics of each participant. We specifically chose to vary age (teenagers, young, young adults), gender, education level, and background. However, we made sure the differences weren’t too obvious in order to avoid possibly embarrassing certain members and to make them feel as comfortable as possible in expressing their opinions. We therefore selected individuals with several interests and occupations, and different profiles. We made sure the focus groups were conducted respecting local norms, in other words, allowing all participants to speak equally and freely creating interactivity between them (Belk, 2006).

The focus group guide was organized in themes related to the understanding of Cool in Tunisia. Various questions were asked to participants related to their perception of Cool using several projective techniques (associative techniques and Chinese portrait technique: associating coolness to countries, persons, brands, ads, colors, etc.) given the ambiguity of the concept and the difficulty of verbally expressing opinions and perceptions, especially for less articulate individuals. These techniques not only allowed consumers to reveal more accurate perceptions of the subjective concept, but also helped us gather important data related to the characteristics of “cool” cultural objects such as personalities, brands, ads, etc. We also opted for projecting award-winning foreign ads (from the Cannes Lion International Festival of Creativity) and local successful ads resulting in the highest perception of “coolness,” along with investigating their perceptions of the characteristics of cool brands, cool celebrities, and personalities.

Averaging 90 minutes each, the focus groups were audio recorded and transcribed allowing us to extract as much information as possible and removing the pressure to take notes and recall accurately all of the discussions. We then conducted lexical, thematic, and semiotic analyses (Miles & Huberman, 1994) on the corpus.

## FINDINGS: HOW IS COOL CONSTRUCTED BY TUNISIANS?

### *Lexical Synonyms of Cool*

When we asked our participants to provide us with synonyms of the term “Cool,” there were no immediate answers delivered. Most individuals refer to “cool” as “cool” and acknowledge that they find it a bit difficult and challenging to come



up with an exact synonym of the term. They took time to think and delivered several synonyms at the same time, in different languages, since we conducted focus groups mainly in Tunisian dialect. Regardless of the multiple meanings attributed to Cool, our findings indicate that for individuals with less familiarity with the concept, it is not known at all for some and for others they have heard it before without knowing what it means.

Divided in three languages (Tunisian dialect, French, and English), French words were the most used as synonyms of Cool by Tunisian individuals. We believe this is due to the fact that the majority of Tunisian individuals have higher language skills in French (Touzani, Smaoui, Kooli, & Ben Yahia, 2013) due to the Tunisian educational system and lifestyles. Individuals with lower education delivered answers in Tunisian Dialect while those with higher education and higher levels of Western acculturation, delivered most of their answer in French followed by English. By combining all three languages together, we find that cool has different meanings among different Tunisians.

Meanings of Cool

*Five shades of cool.* Conducting the *thematic analysis*, we managed to extract five major meanings of cool and to place them on a spectrum, varying the intensity of the emotional arousal stimulated, felt, and expressed by individuals through the association with each concept. Take in Fig. 1 that presents the spectrum of cool in the following:

Based on the origins and the emergence of the term, Cool is mostly seen as linked to meanings of *originality and divergence* in previous works dealing with Cool things, brands, products, personalities, and behaviors in Western countries, with the dominant Cool literature defining it as a non-conformist ideology (Frank, 1997; Heath & Potter, 2010; Pountain & Robins, 2000). In line with literature, several participants tended to link being different and remarkable, creative, standing out, and being exceptional and noticeable to coolness; as opposed to terms like plainness, normality, and boredom designating uncool.

Although this sense was established in our findings, there seem to be other significantly more important and flagrant senses of what is cool in the Tunisian cultural context: It is mainly something “*fun*, funny, *amusing*, and light.”

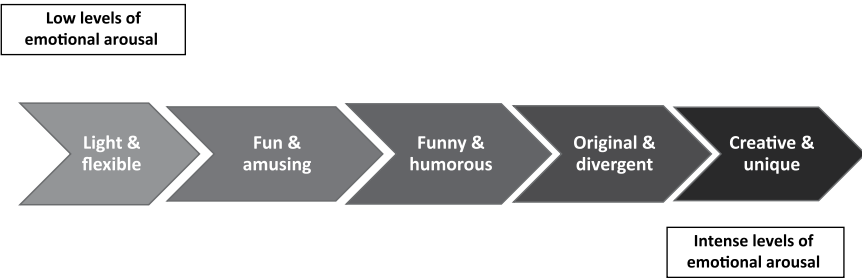


Fig. 1. Five Shades of Cool: Spectrum of Meanings of Coolness.

For the majority of our participants, coolness is sought and desired, and it is highly important to be linked to fun, pleasing, and amusing characteristics associated with someone or something perceived being cool.

Using our projective techniques, several Tunisian consumers (slightly older participants), once asked “If Cool was a color, what would it be?” tended to associate the concept with blue and green colors, explaining that they perceive these latter as symbols of peaceful, relaxing, fresh, and *light*.

If cool was a color for me it would be blue ... Because blue represents for me the sky, freedom, peace, serenity, calm ... relaxation. (Female/46/French professor)

Similarly, meanings of openness, friendliness, and *flexibility* were associated with cool when asked to describe cool personalities. Words like “open minded, easy going, free, friendly, close, approximate, adaptive, flexible” were used as opposed to uncool connotations such as “restrictive, norms, and procedures” that are considered to be freedom inhibiting.

Results also show that participants link *funny and humorous* characteristics to Cool personalities, listing examples of famous comedians as cool people. As cool is most used by our participants in friendly rather than professional contexts, it is indicative of humorous elements. Something Cool is therefore something funny.

*Cool is potentially (explicitly/implicitly) nasty*. Similarly, combining characteristics of humor and originality, some tend to link Cool to *boldness and nastiness* elements. (In the urban American dictionary, nasty is a term used to describe something dirty implying to sexual connotations.) This is established in our findings through the preference of participants of bold ads (containing explicit meanings of nastiness) and/or the ones containing implicit meanings of nastiness believing that integrating funny yet implicitly nasty and dirty elements is perceived to be cool.

*Cool is “the new hot”: Trendy*. Last but not least, participants tend to perceive *trendiness* as cool. Providing us with examples of Brands they perceive to be cool, APPLE was listed several times (in line with the literature), as a very innovative, so “IN” and up to date and finally “the creator of trends to follow” in the High-Tech segment. Similarly, using our projective techniques, when participants were asked about Cool as a country, all answers referred to Western countries, mostly USA, UK, and Australia. Moreover, our findings indicate that individuals with higher education and acculturation *in situ* levels (Touzani et al., 2016) consider western trends as the Cool ones to follow. As stated by the majority of consumers “No one wants to be left behind.” In line with previous literature (Goodman, 2001), following trends is of significant importance when it comes to being perceived as Cool. These trends are however perceived to originate in western countries.

To conclude, Cool is mostly indicative of meanings of lightness and flexibility, fun and amusement, and humor. Several Tunisians also perceive being original and creative as cool. And finally, it is something trendy and potentially nasty.

Interestingly, when using the Tunisian dialectal words, a specific sense of nastiness and boldness emerged when several participants used inappropriate words to indicate cool, insisting, however, on their positive connotations. As we found this quite contradictory, we chose to conduct a *semiotic analysis* on this highly subjective controversial concept and its lexical synonyms and meanings.

A Semiotic Square Analysis of Cool among Tunisians

Semiotic approach studies the content of texts and languages. One of the structural semiotic methodologies that allow text analysis is the semiotic square technique. Defined by [Evrard, Pras, and Roux \(2003\)](#) as a visual representation of the relationships that exist between the distinctive characteristics constituting a semantic category, this technique gathers these distinctive elements under the umbrella of opposite relationships. According to [Floch \(1988\)](#), to construct the semiotic square, one must recognize the existence of two types of opposite relations in languages: the contradiction (by a negation) and the contrariety (opposite meanings). Take in [Fig. 2](#) that illustrates the semiotic square of cool.

As we were investigating the meanings and perceptions of Cool among Tunisian consumers, we collected lexical synonyms of cool as opposed to uncool. Based on this semantic opposition, we opted for the semiotic square analysis method to present the meanings established through our study along with their opposites extracted from the gathered data. As Cool varies from light and flexible, fun and amusing, funny and humorous, different and original, divergent and unique, and potentially nasty and trendy, what is considered uncool is basically the opposites of these senses. Restrictive, serious, dull, boring, and cliché are uncool, while plain and ordinary are non-cool. Take in [Table 1](#) that presents the meanings of Cool along with their opposites following the norms of creation of semiotic square analysis of Cool.

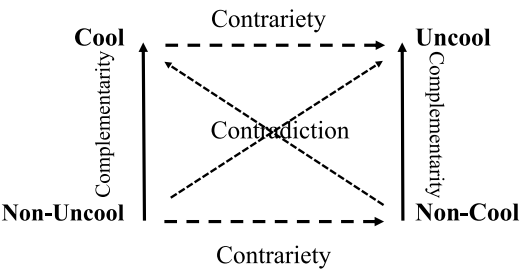


Fig. 2. Semiotic Square of Cool.

Table 1. Meanings of Cool and its Opposites.

|                  | Cool                            | Uncool      | Non-Cool   | Non-Uncool  |
|------------------|---------------------------------|-------------|------------|-------------|
| Meanings of cool | <i>Light &amp; flexible</i>     | Serious     | Dramatic   | Pleasant    |
|                  |                                 | Restrictive | Corporate  | Close       |
|                  |                                 | Square      | Complex    | Proximity   |
|                  | <i>Fun &amp; Amusing</i>        | Boring      | Unexciting | Enchanting  |
|                  |                                 |             | Plain      |             |
|                  | <i>Humorous &amp; funny</i>     | Dull        | Ridiculous | Cheerful    |
|                  |                                 |             | Ironic     | Delightful  |
|                  | <i>Original &amp; different</i> | Normal      | Odd        | Captivating |
|                  |                                 | common      | Strange    | Remarkable  |
|                  | <i>Creative &amp; unique</i>    | Standard    | Abnormal   | Exceptional |
|                  |                                 | Cliché      | Weird      |             |
|                  | <i>Trendy</i>                   | Untrendy    | Usual      | Unusual     |
|                  | <i>Nasty</i>                    | Serious     | Erotic     | Provocative |
|                  |                                 | Restrictive |            |             |

## DISCUSSION AND CONTRIBUTIONS

Our findings indicate that Cool in Tunisia is mostly understood as something light, fun, simple, funny, and close, as opposed to its perceptions in Western countries as something rebellious and divergent, through previous literature (Tapp & Bird, 2008; Warren & Campbell, 2014). We believe this is firstly further evidence that this construct is culturally laden as its meanings change from one culture to another (Frank, 1997; Gerber & Geiman, 2012).

Interestingly, looking back at the origins of the concept of Cool in Western countries, we find it emerged as a way of objection and counter-culturalism against other groups. The “cool self” is authentic as authenticity is “the truest hallmark of cool behavior” (Southgate, 2003). In other words, coolness is a cult of cultural authenticity and an ideology of a microculture cherishing individualism, anti-conformism, and anti-industrialization (Brooks, 2000; Thornton, 1995; Pountain & Robins, 2001). We believe this explains its close association with meanings of rebellion, autonomy, and divergence, long argued in Western literature (Warren & Campbell, 2014).

On the other hand, and as we previously discussed, the emergence of the term “Cool” among Tunisians is recent and it is due to its embrace and embedding of English language in this country along with Tunisians openness to Western culture (Smaoui & Ghariani, 2011). As the concept of cool is considered a social construct and a cultural phenomenon (Frank, 1997; Warren & Campbell, 2014), its perception is highly dependent on the perceiver’s culture. Previous works have established that in the Arab world, Cool is influenced by the West (Rahman & Laud, 2013). Since there is no “story” behind the emergence of Cool among Tunisians, as opposed to its origins in Western culture, Tunisian consumers adopt the meanings of trendiness and fashionability of Cool (especially younger individuals like teenagers and young adults). We believe this explains our findings indicating that this group views Cool as trendy, and these trends are seen as rooted in the Western countries embraced and followed by young Tunisians.

Interestingly, several participants stated that specific Tunisian ads are cool because they contain identity signaling (and potentially vintage) elements and are thus simple, close to the local culture and easily and fluidly transmitted. This is in coherence with previous literature investigating the meanings of styles fluctuating between the global style expression and the local identity projects (Kjeldgaard, 2009). Again, is in line with our most flagrant findings associating Cool to meanings of lightness, proximity, and flexibility. Moreover, as they mostly use it in friendly informal contexts, Tunisian individuals perceive Cool as light, fun, amusing, and funny, similar to the atmosphere in these particular contexts as cherishing fun, joy, and humor (Moalla, 2015). Finally, despite its multiple meanings, Cool is embedded in Tunisian culture and mostly associated with positive connotations, consistent with previous literature (Belk et al., 2010).

Our study presents several contributions. As we note, limited related work investigating the concept of Cool in non-Western cultural contexts exists (Rahman & Laud, 2013). We add to the literature on cool by approaching coolness in emerging-Arab countries, comparing it to the West highlighting the difference established in the meanings when varying cultural contexts. We argue that

this latter is mainly due to the differences between the history of emergence of cool in the West and its embrace among Tunisian consumers; in other words, by taking into consideration the socio-cultural characteristics of the country that potentially altered its meanings. We therefore contributed to the coolness literature by exploring its new identified meanings in a different cultural context. Given the controversy and subjectivity of the concept, we believe conducting an exploratory qualitative research using both lexical and thematic analyses not only helps clarifying ambiguities around its definition, but also facilitates the comprehension of its established meanings among consumers.

Therefore, this provides practitioners operating in this specific cultural frame with a repertoire of perceptions of Cool, and how it is understood and constructed by Tunisian consumers, while varying gender, age, education level, and background. For example, for marketers wishing to position their brands as trendy and modern, light and approximate or funny, integrating Cool into their positioning and marketing communications (selecting Brand name, ads, spokespersons, etc., taking into consideration these established meanings) is most likely to be efficient. However, similar to any other research, our study presents some limitations mostly related to the “sample” as we only selected participants living in Tunis the capital of Tunisia for reasons of availability. Furthermore, as the study is exploratory in nature, the aim was to explore and investigate the meanings of Cool among Tunisian consumers. We thus conducted focus group among participants with varying interpersonal characteristics. We acknowledge the need for conducting more homogeneous focus groups where participants are united by several characteristics for future research. Relatively, it would be interesting to investigate the perception of cool among managers.

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